

STARS 'N' STRIPES



AFP

Kalpana Chawla, the first Indian-born NASA astronaut died on February 1, when space shuttle *Columbia*, carrying a crew of seven astronauts, disintegrated upon re-entry in the Earth's atmosphere. Chawla, as she attained immortality in sudden death, had clocked over 10 million km and 760 hours in space. Born in Karnal, a small town in Haryana, she did her graduation in aeronautical engineering from Punjab Engineering College at Chandigarh and went on to become the second person of Indian origin after cosmonaut Rakesh Sharma to fly in space in 1996. An avid maker of aero-models even as a child, she considered it her birthright to be "a resident of the Milky Way". For her scores of admirers in India, a number swollen by the tragedy of her death, her life was an epigraph of small-town, middle-class success. More so for her as she wore her Indianness on her sleeve, proudly saying at a NASA press briefing, "I am from Karnal, India".

MUMBAI MADNESS

Terror returned to Mumbai when twin bomb blasts rocked the city on August 25. The blasts took place at the Gateway of India and Zaveri Bazaar, killing 52 and injuring 149. The two bombs, which were suspected to have been planted by the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba, were placed in taxis and went off during the peak time.



FIRST CUT

- Welcomed by the tune of "Saare jahaan se achcha" and the raving Mumbai crowd, the first stealth warship, Shivalik, was launched on April 18.

- Israeli Prime Minister Ariel Sharon made the first-ever visit by an Israeli PM to India even as neighbour Pakistan raised its eyebrows and other Islamic countries watched silently.

<< DID YOU KNOW

The Rolling Stones performed for the first time in India in Bangalore, rocking the crowd with their all-time classics like *Satisfaction*, *Street fighting man* and *Sympathy for the devil*.